Reporting suspicious emails with the Report button

Article KB0010083 | Owner: Security Operations | Subcategory: Phishing report | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS laptops (MacBook Pro/Air running macOS 14/15), Outlook desktop client, Outlook on the web (OWA)

Summary

Employees can quickly flag suspicious or phishing emails using the built-in Report button in Outlook (desktop or web). This action sends the message to Security Operations for analysis, triggers automatic remediation, and helps protect the organization. Using the Report button is the fastest way to initiate a phishing investigation and ensures that malicious messages are removed from all mailboxes.

Symptoms

- Unexpected email requesting credentials, payment, or confidential information
- Message with urgent language about an invoice, account verification, or password change
- Sender address that looks similar to a legitimate domain but contains subtle differences (e.g., @acme-example.com instead of @acme.example)
- Presence of unfamiliar links or attachments that you were not expecting

Common causes

- Spoofed or compromised sender address used to impersonate a trusted contact
- Malicious link leading to a credential-harvesting or malware-download site
- Attachment containing malware designed to execute when opened

Overview

The Report button in Outlook is integrated with Microsoft Defender for Office 365. When a user selects Report -> Report as Phishing, the message is forwarded to the Security Operations mailbox, where analysts review it, apply blocks, and purge copies from all user mailboxes. This process also updates threat intelligence feeds to protect other employees.

When to Use the Report Button

Use the Report button whenever you receive an email that seems suspicious, even if you are not certain it is malicious. Examples include requests for passwords, unexpected invoices, or messages that create a sense of urgency. Reporting early helps Security Operations act before any potential compromise occurs.

Self-Help Procedure for Users

Follow these steps to report a suspicious email from either the Outlook desktop client or Outlook on the web. The process takes only a few seconds and does not require any additional tools.

1. Open the suspicious email in Outlook.
2. In the message ribbon, locate the **Report Message** button (or the **More actions** (...) menu if the button is not visible).
3. Click **Report Message**, then select **Report as Phishing** from the dropdown list.
4. A confirmation dialog appears; confirm that you want to send the message to Security Operations.
5. After submission, the email is moved to the Deleted Items folder and a copy is forwarded for analysis. You may close the message.

Service Desk Agent Procedure

When a user contacts the service desk about a suspected phishing email, the agent should first verify that the user has used the Report button. If not, guide them through the self-help steps. After confirmation, the agent creates a ticket and notifies Security Operations for further analysis.

1. Ask the user whether they have already clicked the Report button in Outlook.
2. If they have not, walk them through the self-help procedure outlined above.
3. Once the user confirms the report, open a new incident ticket in the ITSM system.
4. In the ticket, capture the following details: sender address, subject line, time received, and any screenshots the user

can provide.
5. Assign the ticket to the Security Operations group with priority P2 (High) unless evidence suggests active compromise, in which case raise to P1.
6. Inform the user that Security Operations will analyze the message, block the sender, and purge copies from all mailboxes; they will be notified of the outcome.

Verification and Follow-Up

After a phishing report is submitted, Security Operations performs several automated and manual actions. The message is scanned for malicious URLs or attachments, the sender's address is added to the block list, and any copies found in user mailboxes are removed. Users receive an automated notification when the analysis is complete, and the ticket is closed accordingly.

When to escalate

If the Security Operations analyst determines that the email led to credential entry, malware execution, or signs of compromise, the incident must be escalated immediately. Escalate to the Security Operations team lead (or the Incident Response manager) with priority P1. Include in the escalation: full email headers, any captured payload or URL, timestamp of user interaction, and the actions already taken (password reset, session revocation, sign-in review).

Keywords: phishing, report button, suspicious email, fake invoice, password request, Outlook report, security operations, phish alert, email threat